



**MINISTRY OF HEALTH
STATE DEPARTMENT FOR PUBLIC HEALTH AND PROFESSIONAL STANDARDS
OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL SECRETARY**

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Ref: MOH/ADM/1/2/52

22nd July 2026

All County Executive Committee Members for Health (CECM-Health)
All County Directors of Health (CDH)
All Chief Officers for Health (COH)

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Mary Mwitl, EBS
Chief Executive Officer
Council of Governors
Delta House, Westlands
NAIROBI



Dear *Mary*

**RE: ADVISORY TO COUNTY GOVERNMENTS REGARDING PESTICIDE
RESIDUES IN FRESH PRODUCE SOLD IN PUBLIC MARKETS**

1. Background

The Ministry of Health has reviewed a recent study conducted by the Kenya Organic Agriculture Network, the University of Nairobi, and SGS Kenya Laboratories, which tested fresh produce samples including onions, tomatoes, kale, and spinach from major markets in Nairobi and Nakuru. The study found that 77.8 percent of samples contained detectable pesticide residues, with roughly one-third exceeding internationally recognized safety thresholds. Kale and spinach samples were found to carry residues of up to seven different pesticides.

This advisory sets out the Ministry's guidance to counties on immediate and near-term action, pending a full inter-agency review.

2. Risk Context

Counties should note that these findings relate to cumulative, long-term exposure risk rather than acute danger from any single meal. This distinction should guide the tone of any county-level public communication: the objective is to strengthen food safety practices, not to discourage vegetable consumption.

3. Immediate Actions Requested of Counties

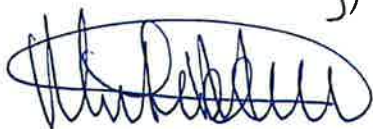
County health departments are advised to:

1. **Market surveillance:** Intensify inspection and, where feasible, sampling of fresh produce at major county markets, prioritizing kale, spinach, tomatoes, and onions.
2. **Public communication:** Disseminate guidance to households on preparation practices shown to reduce pesticide residues by 60-70 percent, including thorough washing, soaking, and peeling where appropriate. Suggested messaging will be circulated separately.
3. **Coordination with traders and producers:** Engage county-level produce traders and, where applicable, producer associations, to reinforce awareness of maximum residue level (MRL) standards and pre-harvest interval requirements.
4. **Reporting:** Submit a summary of current market inspection capacity, and any locally held produce-testing data, to the Ministry
5. **Referral pathway:** Where residue levels of concern are identified locally, notify the Pest Control Products Board (PCPB) and Kenya Plant Health Inspectorate Service (KEPHIS) through the established reporting channel, copying the Ministry.

4. National-Level Follow-Up

The Ministry is convening an inter-agency task force with PCPB, KEBS, KEPHIS, and the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development to review the study in full and recommend regulatory follow-up. Counties will be briefed on outcomes and any revised guidance in due course.

Yours

Sincerely,


Mary Muthoni Muriuki, CBS
PRINCIPAL SECRETARY



MINISTRY OF HEALTH

**OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL SECRETARY
STATE DEPARTMENT FOR PUBLIC HEALTH & PROFESSIONAL STANDARDS**

**PRESS RELEASE
FOR IMMEDIATE RELEASE
22nd July 2026**

RE: REPORT ON PESTICIDE RESIDUES IN FRESH PRODUCE

Nairobi, Kenya

The Ministry of Health has taken note of the recently published study by the Kenya Organic Agriculture Network (KOAN), the University of Nairobi, and SGS Kenya Laboratories, which found detectable pesticide residues in a majority of vegetable samples tested from major markets in Nairobi and Nakuru. We thank the researchers for this important contribution to the country's food safety evidence base.

The Ministry recognizes the seriousness of these findings, particularly regarding kale and spinach samples found to carry multiple pesticide residues. We wish to assure the public that the presence of detectable residues does not mean that eating vegetables poses an immediate health danger. The concern raised by the study relates to long-term, cumulative exposure, not acute risk from any single meal. Kenyans should continue to include vegetables as part of a healthy, balanced diet.

The Ministry also notes the study's finding that simple household preparation practices thorough washing, soaking, and peeling where appropriate "can reduce pesticide residues by 60 to 70 percent before consumption. We encourage all households to adopt these practices as a practical, immediate safeguard.

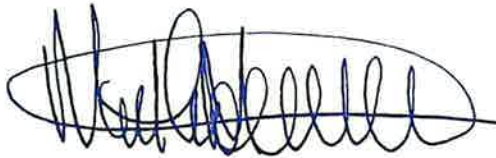
Action steps

The Ministry of Health is committed to working with the Pest Control Products Board (PCPB), KEBS, the Kenya Plant Health Inspectorate Service (KEPHIS), the Ministry of Agriculture and Livestock Development, and county governments to:

1. Strengthen routine surveillance and testing of fresh produce sold in public markets across the country.
2. Review and reinforce enforcement of maximum residue level (MRL) standards and pre-harvest interval compliance among producers.

3. Support public education campaigns on safe food handling and preparation practices to reduce household-level exposure.
4. Engage with farmers and agrochemical regulators to promote adoption of safer, integrated pest management practices.
5. Convene an inter-agency food safety task force to review the study's findings in full and recommend follow-up regulatory action

The Ministry will continue to monitor this issue closely and will provide updates as further testing and interventions are undertaken.

A handwritten signature in blue ink, consisting of a large, stylized 'M' followed by several loops and a long horizontal stroke.

Mary Muthoni Muriuki, CBS
PRINCIPAL SECRETARY